

Joy and unease in a city Assads ruled

In Damascus, Syrians search for a new identity in a capital seemingly dominated by bearded militants.

By NABIH BULOS

DAMASCUS, Syria — They streamed in by the thousands, deluging Damascus' Umayyad Square in a sea of cars and people for an impromptu parade to celebrate the stealthy flight of former Syrian President Bashar Assad the morning before.

"Raise your head high. You are a free Syrian," blared a voice from a bank of loudspeakers atop a pickup truck parked nearby. To the side, a gaggle of young men and children swarmed over an abandoned Syrian army tank, chanting "May Allah curse your soul, Hafez," — a reference to Assad's father, Hafez, who ruled Syria for three decades before his death.

Meanwhile, dozens of militants kept up a near-constant staccato of celebratory machine gun fire, leaving a carpet of spent cartridges on the asphalt.

Off to the side, a young man stomped at the singed copies of a tome titled "The speech on tenets and the national decision by President Bashar Al-Assad," which bore a portrait of the former president.

"That scumbag, we're finally rid of him," he said, emphasizing the words by stepping on Assad's image before rushing to join the crowd in the center of the square.

Over the centuries, Damascus has been many things: a metropolis that served as the center of an Islamic caliphate; a hotbed for Arab anti-colonialist stirrings; and the seat of a political dynasty that was one of the defining forces of the Arab world's contemporary political landscape. It now searches for a new identity, as its residents wake up to the post-Assad reality and the thousands of scruffy, bearded militants who have — seemingly overnight — sprouted at every major intersection and state institution.

For many Damascenes, the dominant feelings are a mix of joy and trepidation.

"We're happy, of course, but we're afraid of what's coming," said Muna Maidani, a 28-year-old who was walking near Umayyad Square — one of the Syrian capital's most famous landmarks — with her two children.

Was the rebels' entry into [See Syria, A4]



OMAR SANADIKI Associated Press

AN IMAGE of ousted Syrian President Bashar Assad is burned Monday in Damascus, the capital. "It was ruled by a tyrant, but now we'll build a new Syria," said Abdul-Ilah Hmoud, a rebel fighter from Idlib province.

Jay-Z named in Combs case after lawyers fought in private

Music mogul denies rape allegation as he files a countersuit

By HANNAH FRY AND RICHARD WINTON

The public naming of Jay-Z as the mysterious celebrity accused in an anonymous civil lawsuit of raping a 13-year-old girl with Sean "Diddy" Combs came after weeks of behind-the-scenes battling between the star's lawyer and the Texas attorney representing the woman.

Since Combs was charged by federal

prosecutors in a salacious sex trafficking investigation, numerous civil lawsuits have been filed from people claiming they were victimized by the entertainer. There have also been suggestions that other big names will be swept into the scandal.

But the Jay-Z case offers a window into the machinations and big money behind such cases that could be a preview of the potential fallout involving other civil litigation that's been filed against Combs.

In October, Jay-Z received a demand letter from Texas-based attorney Tony Buzbee making allegations of misconduct and suggesting a meeting. Legal experts said such letters are a common way to begin settlement discussions.

But this letter included picture of a ticking clock and Jay-Z came out swinging.

The music mogul responded by filing his own anonymous lawsuit against [See Jay-Z, A9]

'Zero progress' on Colorado River

Western states are at impasse in talks on new rules for water shortages

By IAN JAMES

Seven Western states that depend on the Colorado River are ending the year at an impasse in negotiations over the writing of new rules for dealing with chronic water shortages.

Representatives of California and other states who attended an annual Colorado River conference in Las Vegas last week said they remain deadlocked in their talks on long-term plans for reducing water use to prevent the river's reservoirs from reaching critically low levels.

Disagreements over competing proposals have created a deep rift between two camps: the three states in the river's lower basin — California, Arizona and Nevada — and the four states in [See Colorado River, A6]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

A TRACTOR kicks up dust at a farm in the Imperial Valley. The Biden administration has been paying farmers to temporarily leave fields dry to cut water use.

TRUMP'S L.A. GAINS

A political shift in 'Mexican Beverly Hills'

A surge of migrants at the border. President Biden's debate performance. High interest rates. Phillip can tick off the reasons he voted for President-elect Donald Trump.

But that doesn't mean the first-generation Mexican American is a full-throated Republican. And he sure doesn't want his neighbors knowing how he voted.

"Downey is a small community," he said while walking with his wife and two dogs at dusk along a quiet street of lush lawns and wide, flat streets. Support-

Downey, like other largely Latino cities in southeast Los Angeles County, saw a big tilt toward GOP nominee

By RACHEL URANGA

ing Trump antagonizes people around here.

Downey, a suburb about 10 miles southeast of downtown Los Angeles, has become a landing spot for upwardly mobile and wealthy Latinos, so much so it has been dubbed "the Mexican Beverly Hills." And like many other parts of the middle- and working-class southeast county, the so-called Gateway Cities, it has seen a shift in support toward Donald Trump.

Trump didn't win any precinct in [See Downey, A9]

Arrest is made in CEO's slaying

Police take Luigi Mangione, 26, into custody after he's spotted at a Pennsylvania eatery. **NATION, A5**

'Emilia Pérez' top awards nominee

The Spanish-language musical is in contention for 10 Golden Globes. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 74/50. **B6**

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OpenAI's film tool Sora is here

The video generator is released to the public. Will it disrupt Hollywood? **BUSINESS, A8**

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